

INDIA'S PILOT FATIGUE REGULATIONS

The Aeronautical Information Circular establishes India's first modern national FDTL framework

1992



A new Civil Aviation Requirement (CAR) is introduced for "greater benefit of pilots." Airlines claim it is impossible to follow; it is kept in abeyance

2007



Based on Nasim Zaidi Committee report, this CAR becomes the new legal standard for FDTL, replacing the 1992 circular

2011



Post-Mangalore crash, guidelines set to strictly count duty/travel time. Implementation delayed under operator pressure, leading to a Supreme Court contempt notice against the DGCA

2012



A more advanced version is implemented and becomes the FDTL baseline for all scheduled airlines, till the 2024 reforms

2019



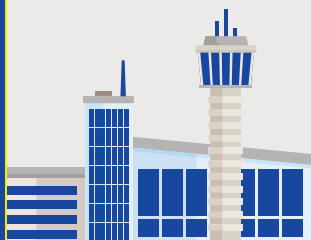
Revised fatigue norms set for June, 2024 roll-out. Put in abeyance in March 2024 after airlines argue they cannot meet the capacity impact

2024



Court-mandated rules finally go live in Nov 2025. IndiGo given extension till Feb 2026

2025



announced a further increase in some of these charges.

Aviation turbine fuel attracts 11% central excise duty. States and Union Territories levy different rates of value-added tax ranging from 0 to 29%. "The government is not doing anything despite the issues being flagged repeatedly. The big industrialists do not want to enter the aviation sector. So, how can the government look to have five big airlines in the country when its policies are not conducive?" he says.

Lazar says China is perhaps the closest model we can adopt. The country has four big airlines with around 25% share each. "They have developed so well, it's amazing," he says.

The episode has also brought into focus the need for an independent authority to safeguard India's aviation growth story and a regulatory overhaul to allow more airlines to flourish in a duopoly market. The DGCA has been drawing flak over its failure to gauge the situation before approving the airline's capacity addition plans.

The DGCA comes under the Ministry of Civil Aviation and is not independent. There have been talks about having a CAA (Civil Aviation Authority). The DGCA had written to airlines on FDTL implementation for the first time from March 2024 onwards, but the ministry of civil aviation asked it to withdraw, following pressure from airlines, primarily IndiGo, according to reports.

About 50% of 1,600 posts at the DGCA have been lying vacant despite the ambitious expansion plans of airlines. It has to be seen if the IndiGo incident ushers in the much-needed reforms to support the projected aviation boom. **BT**

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